



Diana with stag centrepiece

△ **Altarpiece** by Matthäus Walbaum of Augsburg, Bavaria

This statuette depicting Diana, goddess of the hunt, is not merely a decorative centrepiece, but also a drinking vessel and automaton used in early 17th-century party games.

The statuette, 32.5cm (14in) in height, is made from silver parcel-gilt (partially gilded) with repoussé work, and red coral forming the stag's antlers. It depicts the Greek goddess Diana riding a stag, accompanied by two hunting dogs. This example was likely to have been made by goldsmith Matthäus Walbaum of Augsburg, Bavaria, or one of his circle. The base of the statuette once contained



Another automaton depicting Diana, Eltz Castle, Germany

wheels powered by a clockwork mechanism, now missing, which could be wound with a key in a slot on the side. The automaton was placed on the table at dinner parties, wound up, and then released, at which point it wheeled off, making many arbitrary turns before stopping in front of one of the guests. The stag, which is hollow, would have been filled

with wine by the host and the guest was required to drain it, removing the head and using it as a cup.

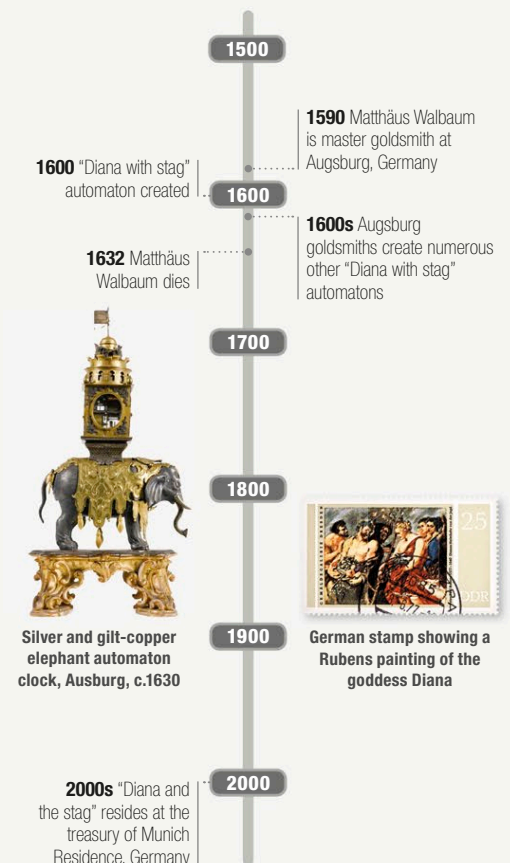
These wind-up sculptures proved popular in the 1600s and 1700s, and "Diana on a stag" was a favourite theme of the renowned Augsburg goldsmiths; around 30 such statues survive, all produced by three of the city's goldsmiths. Walbaum probably created the earliest example. Other variations of Diana from this period, such as the automaton at Eltz Castle, Germany, reserved the stag for the men, with a smaller, hollow hound for the ladies. Chains attached to the cups meant participants had to drink in close proximity to one another.



Statue of Diana, which stood in Madison Square Garden, New York, until 1925. The day it was removed, it attracted crowds of onlookers

Key dates

1590–2000s



One of the most productive goldsmith's workshops in Augsburg

Grove Encyclopedia of Decorative Arts on Matthäus Walbaum's workshop